



QUATTROCCHI AT A MALAYSIAN COURT

DELHI | Smoked Out Gun

It's a case that brought down the Rajiv Gandhi government, proved to be a millstone around the neck of the Congress in every subsequent election and tarnished several reputations. On September 29, nineteen years after the CBI first registered a complaint, the Government told the Supreme Court that it had decided to withdraw the case against Delhi-based Italian businessman Ottavio Quattrocchi, a close friend of the Gandhi family who stood accused in a case relating to the payment of Rs 64 crore as commission in the Bofors howitzer deal. Quattrocchi, who fled India in 1993, has since fought several attempts at extradition by Indian authorities, from Malaysia as well as Argentina, where he was last residing. The Centre told the apex court that the CBI has decided to close the case since all attempts at extradition have failed as also because the Delhi High Court had held that no case of corruption existed. Ever since the UPA came to power in 2004, key ministers looking after law and defence have systematically tried to ensure that the case is brought to a close. As expected, the BJP reacted strongly and accused the CBI of tarnishing its image by "colluding with the Government to set the guilty free". But the UPA hit back, saying that despite making the Bofors issue one of its main electoral planks, the BJP-led NDA government was not able to make any headway in punishing the guilty. **by Shafi Rahman**

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years after the first complaint in the case, the Indian Government has finally decided to withdraw the case against Quattrocchi.